

Skills of the future

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DESCRIPTION

Imagine this: you're about to meet your new colleagues, and someone whispers that every one of them is more intelligent than Albert Einstein. Intimidating, right?

That's the reality we're stepping into. Workplaces will be filled with advanced AIs — brilliant, tireless, and beyond anything we've known. Frightening? Maybe.

But here's the good news: humans still hold five unique advantages. We can see the bigger picture. We connect through social intelligence and storytelling. We adapt. We make decisions in complex, messy systems. And we still spark ideas no machine can replicate.

This course is designed not to alarm, but to equip you. You'll learn to sharpen these skills with practical techniques you can apply immediately. By the end, you won't just understand these advantages — you'll embody them.

So when you walk into that future workplace, you'll feel ready — not overshadowed, but confident, prepared to thrive alongside AI.

OBJECTIVES

This course strengthens the human skills that matter most in an AI-driven world. You will learn to:

- Think more clearly and strategically by seeing the big picture.
- Manage your career and choices with intention by strengthening your decision-making skills.
- Navigate change and complexity with confidence by staying adaptive and creative.
- Build trust and influence by using social intelligence and storytelling.
- Develop the leadership capacity to integrate thinking, deciding, creating, adapting, and influencing – when problems are ambiguous and stakes are high.

MATERIALS

Readings and videos

(All the material appears here via links.)

Introduction
- Is this how AI might destroy humanity? (video, 5 min) - David Author with some positive news (video, 4 min) - Future of jobs report (read pages 32-48, 12 min)
Big-picture thinking
- The Eureka Factor: Aha Moments, Creative Insight and the Brain (video, 5 min) - The Matrix (1999) Trailer (video, 2 min) - Zoom out for perspective in life (video, 1 min) - Focus on one thing (video, 1 min)
Storytelling
- Conflict in literature (video, 2 min) - How to use conflict (video, 6 min) [Similar to the above, but worth watching both.] - Shape of stories (video, 5 min) - Listeners and Tappers Problem (reading, 1 min) - Your brain on fiction (reading, 5 min) - Stories brings people together (reading, 5 min)
Career management
- The science of success (read the first three pages, 4 min) - Simon Sinek on managing a career (video, 2 min) - Work as a calling (read the first three pages, 10 min) - Range by David Epstein (video, 5 min)
Adaptivity
- The advantages of adaptivity (video, 3 min) - Students are expected to read specific items for assignment 2.
Creativity
- Generating creative ideas (video, 2 min) - Task unification (video, 2 min) - The strategic genius of Taylor Swift (video, 20 min)
Social intelligence
- Social Intelligence: 5 Mental Gifts to Succeed in Society (video, 6 min) - How To Improve Your Social Intelligence (video, 5 min)

SCHEDULE

Date	Class Topic	Assignments due
Week 1	Introduction + Big picture thinking	
Week 2	Big picture thinking	
Week 3	Big picture thinking	
Week 4	Communication and storytelling	1
Week 5	Communication and storytelling	
Week 6	Career management	
Week 7	Adaptivity	2
Week 8	Creativity	
Week 9	Social intelligence	3
Week 10	Social intelligence	4
Exam week	Final project	5

ASSIGNMENTS

#	Points	Group or Individual	Description	Due (Session #)
1	30	Group	Solve a challenging problem	4
2	10	Group	Prepare a presentation	7
3	25	Group	Develop a creative idea	9
4	10	Individual	Write a personal story	10
5	25	Individual	Continue building your skills	Exam week

Reading Assignments

See above, in “Materials”.

Team Projects

Assignments 1-3 as appears above.

Quizzes and Exams

None.

Class Participation Attendance and Participation

Students are expected to come prepared for class and actively share their insights in discussion. Up to 5 bonus points may be awarded for participation and preparedness, based on both the quality of contributions and the consistency and persistence of engagement throughout the course.

GRADING

Assignments	Points [or percentage]
1	30
2	10
3	25
4	10
5	25

CHATGPT AND OTHER AI TOOLS

This course encourages thoughtful and transparent use of artificial intelligence tools as part of your learning process. You are invited to treat AI as a **thinking partner** – a resource for exploration, refinement, and feedback – not as a substitute for your own analysis or creativity.

Guidelines for using AI (from the assignment document)

Allowed: Editing, formatting, summarizing notes, checking grammar, and refining phrasing or structure.

Allowed with disclosure: Using AI to generate ideas, outlines, or phrasing. If you use AI to generate any part of your analysis or phrasing, you must include a short AI Usage Note at the end of your report, as well as briefly state what prompts or tasks you used AI for. Also, explain how you verified, modified, or improved the AI's output, and provide at least one example of that.

Recommended: Use AI as a **thinking partner**, not a writer – to question assumptions, test reasoning, explore alternatives, or clarify structure.

Purpose of this policy

The goal is to help you develop judgment about when and how to use AI responsibly – building your capacity to combine human insight with technological support. This aligns with the course's broader focus.

COURSE POLICIES

For each class meeting, you will receive: (1) a detailed and comprehensive class summary prepared by the professor and the teaching assistant; (2) all presentation slides, including a list of the most important slides; and (3) a link to the class recording.

The purpose of this policy is to free you to focus fully on class discussion rather than on note-taking. Accordingly, you may use a paper tablet in class, but no other devices are permitted.

ACADEMIC INTEGRITY

Integrity of scholarship is essential for an academic community. As members of the Rady School, we pledge ourselves to uphold the highest ethical standards. The University expects that both faculty and

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students will honor this principle and in so doing protect the validity of University intellectual work. For students, this means that all academic work will be done by the individual to whom it is assigned, without unauthorized aid of any kind.

The complete UCSD Policy on Integrity of Scholarship can be viewed at:
<http://senate.ucsd.edu/Operating-Procedures/Senate-Manual/Appendices/2>

STUDENTS WITH DISABILITIES

A student who has a disability or special need and requires an accommodation in order to have equal access to the classroom must register with the Office for Students with Disabilities (OSD). The OSD will determine what accommodations may be made and provide the necessary documentation to present to the faculty member.

The student must present the OSD letter of certification and OSD accommodation recommendation to the appropriate faculty member in order to initiate the request for accommodation in classes, examinations, or other academic program activities. **No accommodations can be implemented retroactively.**

Please visit the [OSD website](#) for further information or contact the Office for Students with Disabilities at (858) 534-4382 or osd@ucsd.edu.